

RCM Specialist Badge Competency Matrix

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How the badge system works

A badge certifies that a specialist can do one task type alone at production quality; it controls what work ClickUp routes to them and which level they can reach. Every specialist in a full-cycle team is assessed against the same badges, whatever their previous title (coder, biller or negotiator).

Earning a badge follows four steps, the same for every badge:

1. **Academy module.** Training run by the Academy owner (see Who runs the badge program), ending in a written or practical check.
2. **Supervised production.** A set number of real cases done under a badge-holder's review. The holder signs off each case in ClickUp.
3. **Assessment.** The Badge Panel scores a practical test plus a random sample of the supervised cases.
4. **Award.** The Academy owner confirms the badge. Routing rights switch on the same day.

Common rules:

- QA scores use the QA department's checklist for each badge. A **critical error** (missed deadline, wrong payer or patient, PHI sent to the wrong party, unsupported code) fails the case regardless of score.
- Assessors may not assess members of their own team.
- Thresholds below are starting values. The Academy owner and the QA department review them after the first two quarters of data.

Who runs the badge program

The Training Academy Committee runs the program, chaired by a manager (preferably the Senior Manager). The QA department checks quality, and senior specialists assess. The Badges, Levels and Transition appendix sets the levels, test windows and badge-loss rules, and takes precedence where it differs from this matrix.

Role	Who	Responsibilities
Academy Committee chair	A manager, preferably the Senior Manager (L5)	Training calendar, badge records, award decisions, quarterly test windows, semiannual review, monthly team badge grid
Academy Committee	2–3 managers, 2 L4 Senior Specialists II, 2 L3 Senior Specialists I, 2 rotating team leads, 1 QA reviewer	Calibrates awards, placements and promotions
Badge Panel	A QA department reviewer plus 2 L4 Senior Specialists II or team leads from other teams	Scores assessments and samples of supervised cases
QA department	The existing, separate QA department	QA checklists and scores, coding audit sample (5–10% of charts)
Pricing guide owner	A team manager, with the A4 Payer Strategy holders	Offer pricing guide and payer playbooks
Onshore–Offshore Liaison owner	A team manager	Ticket quality, coordination with the US desk; the bridge night rota reports here
Trainers	L4 Senior Specialists II and team leads	Teach Academy modules; teaching counts toward L4

Badges to levels

Level is set by badges held plus results on the specialist's own portfolio; former title plays no part. Promotion is reviewed quarterly, and a level is confirmed only when both columns are met for two consecutive months.

Level	Badges required	Performance required	Portfolio tier	Typical role
L1 RCM Specialist I	Working toward the 5 core badges	Meets work-unit target after 90 days; QA at or above 90%	Tier 3 (low-dollar, high-volume)	New hire or retraining
L2 RCM Specialist II	All 5 core badges	Work units at or above 100% of target; QA at or above 95%; zero missed deadlines in the quarter	Tier 2 (standard NSA)	Full-cycle account owner
L3 Senior Specialist I	All core + 2 advanced from A1, A2 and A3	Net Recovery in the top 40% of the tier; QA at or above 97%	Tier 1 (high-dollar, hardest payers)	Team expert, peer QA, mentor; eligible for team lead
L4 Senior Specialist II	All core + A2 + A4 + either A1 or A3	Net Recovery in the top 20% of the tier; teaches at least one Academy module	Tier 1 + one specialty-group lead	Specialty-group lead, Badge Panel assessor, Academy trainer
L5 Principal (Leadership)	Team leads, managers and the Senior Manager only	Set by the leadership role	A team or a portfolio	Team Lead, Manager, Senior Manager

Leadership (L5): Team Lead requires L3 or L4 plus a coaching assessment. Manager requires 12 months as a team lead, or L4 plus leadership training. Leaders keep their badges and their QA reviews.

Core badges (all five required for L2)

The core badges cover all the routine work on an account, so any L2 can own an account end to end and cover for a colleague.

C1. Claim Follow-up and Receipt Confirmation

Element	Standard
Unlocks	Confirming payer receipt of paper claims, status follow-up by portal and phone, resubmission requests to Logistics, attaching received documents to the patient hub
Prerequisite	None
Competency criteria	Logs the mail date for every claim; confirms payer receipt within 21 days of mailing; every open claim has a next-action date; correct ClickUp status on every touch; follows the payer call script and records the reference number
Supervised production	40 claims across at least 5 payers
Assessment	Live status check of 10 claims with the assessor watching; review of 3 recorded payer calls
QA to earn	95% or higher on the supervised cases
QA to keep	93% or higher each quarter
Critical errors	Claim left without a next-action date for more than 14 days; wrong patient or payer on a call; documents attached to the wrong account

C2. Open Negotiation (OMB)

Element	Standard
Unlocks	Determining NSA eligibility at the initial payment or denial, sending the Open Negotiation notice (OMB form), running the 30-business-day negotiation period, settling within decision rights, logging the outcome
Prerequisite	C1

Element	Standard
Competency criteria	Classifies NSA eligibility correctly (emergency service, out of network, plan type, date of initial payment or denial); notice is complete with the right claim items and QPA and sent with proof of delivery inside the 30-business-day window; negotiation counter-offers follow the pricing guide; every settlement is inside the specialist's decision rights or approved by the TL or manager
Supervised production	30 notices and 10 negotiations
Assessment	Eligibility test of 20 scenarios (90% or higher); one practical notice; one negotiation role-play scored by the assessor
QA to earn	98% or higher (deadline-critical work)
QA to keep	97% or higher each quarter
Critical errors	Notice sent outside the window; wrong items or missing QPA; settlement accepted beyond decision rights

C3. NNSA Appeal

Element	Standard
Unlocks	Code appeals and money appeals under the NNSA process maps, including state-regulated plan claims; non-NSA denial resolution; applying the 12-month closing rule
Prerequisite	C1
Competency criteria	Selects the right appeal type; uses the approved letter template and cites the medical-necessity report; files within the payer's appeal limit; recommends closure at 12 months from DOS, with a final review for high-dollar claims
Supervised production	25 appeals covering at least 2 appeal types

Element	Standard
Assessment	Writes 2 appeals from case files; scored by the Badge Panel
QA to earn	95% or higher
QA to keep	93% or higher each quarter
Critical errors	Appeal filed after the payer's limit; letter sent without supporting documents; claim closed without the required review

C4. Payment Posting and Reconciliation

Element	Standard
Unlocks	Working the ERA exception queue, manual posting (about 10% of payments), posting IDR award payments, adjustments, refund flags, claim closure
Prerequisite	None
Competency criteria	Posted amounts match the remittance to the cent; correct adjustment codes; IDR award payments matched to the determination within 2 business days of receipt; awards still unpaid 30 calendar days after the determination are flagged for follow-up
Supervised production	100 postings, including at least 20 manual and 10 IDR award payments
Assessment	Posting test of 30 items; the batch must balance exactly
QA to earn	99% or higher
QA to keep	98% or higher each quarter
Critical errors	Posting to the wrong account; unbalanced batch; claim closed with an open balance

C5. Medical-Necessity Report and Documentation

Element	Standard
Unlocks	Generating the medical-necessity report with the approved LLM prompt library, reviewing and correcting it against the chart, filing it to the patient hub
Prerequisite	None
Competency criteria	Uses only the current approved prompt version in the approved tool; every fact in the report is in the chart; covers presenting complaint, acuity, workup, treatment and disposition; filed within 1 business day of coding
Supervised production	30 reports
Assessment	Produces reports for 5 charts; the assessor checks each against the chart; zero factual errors allowed
QA to earn	97% or higher, with zero factual errors
QA to keep	96% or higher each quarter
Critical errors	Any statement not supported by the chart; wrong patient; PHI entered into an unapproved tool

Advanced badges (2 for L3; A2, A4 and one more for L4)

Advanced badges mark the team's experts; each team needs at least 2 holders of each. They carry stricter review cycles because errors here cost the most.

A1. Coding (Certified)

Element	Standard
Unlocks	ER professional and facility coding: E/M level, procedures, ICD-10, modifiers, claim scrubbing, HCFA and UB-04 preparation for Logistics
Prerequisite	Active coding certification (CPC, COC or CCS); C5

Element	Standard
Competency criteria	E/M level supported by the documentation; no unsupported level or code; correct modifiers; scrubbed claim passes edits on the first try; about 50 charts per coding day at full productivity
Supervised production	200 charts: 100% review of the first 50, then a 20% sample
Assessment	Blind coding test of 50 charts; 95% or higher accuracy
QA to earn	95% or higher
QA to keep	95% or higher on the QA department's audit sample (5-10% of charts), reviewed monthly ; certification kept active
Critical errors	Code or level not supported by the documentation; wrong patient or date of service

A2. IDR Packet and Offer Strategy

Element	Standard
Unlocks	Initiation and batching decisions, tickets to the US Gateway Desk, IDRE selection decisions, choosing offer amounts, writing the packet, logging determinations, reviewing outcomes
Prerequisite	C2 and C5
Competency criteria	Batching rules applied correctly (same payer, same or similar service codes, within the allowed window); offers follow the pricing guide; packet answers the QPA and the additional factors (acuity, complexity, good-faith negotiation); US desk tickets complete and correct on the first pass; zero missed deadlines
Supervised production	20 batched disputes end to end, covering at least 160 codes

Element	Standard
Assessment	Case study: full packet and written offer rationale for one batched dispute; reviewed by a panel of 2 L4 Senior Specialists II or Badge Panel assessors
QA to earn	97% or higher, and 98% or higher first-pass ticket accuracy
QA to keep	96% or higher and 97% or higher first-pass ticket accuracy, reviewed monthly
Critical errors	Missed initiation, selection or offer deadline; ticket that causes a wrong submission on the gateway; offer outside the pricing guide without approval

A3. MVA and Adjuster Negotiation

Element	Standard
Unlocks	Auto-carrier claims, PIP and MedPay, liability claims, attorney and lien correspondence, settlement negotiation with adjusters
Prerequisite	C1 and C3
Competency criteria	Identifies the order of coverage before billing; files within carrier limits; documents every offer and counter-offer; settles within decision rights; releases records only with valid authorization
Supervised production	15 settlements
Assessment	Negotiation role-play with the assessor acting as the adjuster; review of 3 closed case files
QA to earn	95% or higher
QA to keep	93% or higher each quarter
Critical errors	Settlement below decision rights without approval; records released without authorization

A4. Payer Strategy

Element	Standard
Unlocks	Owning the playbook for 1-2 payers: QPA patterns, negotiation behavior, IDRE outcome trends, recommended offer ranges, escalation contacts; presenting monthly to the specialty group
Prerequisite	A2 and L2 or above
Competency criteria	Playbook updated at least monthly; every recommendation backed by outcome data; measurable change in Net Recovery on the payer within 2 quarters
Supervised production	Co-own one payer playbook with an L4 Senior Specialist II for 1 quarter
Assessment	Presents the playbook to the Badge Panel and defends its recommendations
QA to earn	90% or higher on the panel's playbook scorecard
QA to keep	90% or higher on the quarterly playbook review; no section older than 45 days
Critical errors	Recommendation contradicting the outcome data; playbook shared outside the team

Keeping, suspending and covering badges

A badge is kept only while its QA holds: one review below the bar triggers coaching, and two in a row suspend it. Every June 30 and December 31, a semiannual KPI review decides which badges each member keeps. Consequences start with the December 2027 review.

Situation	What happens	Who decides
One review below the keep threshold	Written coaching plan; 100% review of that badge's work for 30 days	TL

Situation	What happens	Who decides
Two consecutive reviews below the threshold	Badge suspended; that work routes to other holders in the team; re-earn it in the next test window, after half the original supervised case count	Academy chair, with the team manager informed
Any critical error	Case reviewed within 2 business days; a second critical error within 90 days counts as a failed review	TL, escalated to manager
Semiannual review (June 30 and December 31)	A badge is lost if, over the half-year, its QA is below the keep threshold, it has 2 or more critical errors, or it was suspended and not re-earned	Academy Committee
25% or more of badges lost in a half-year	90-day probation and coaching: written plan, 100% review of the affected work, weekly check-ins, re-test in the next window	Team manager and Academy chair
50% or more of badges lost in a half-year	Termination through the HR process, with one appeal (subject to HR and legal review)	Director, on the committee's recommendation
Badge needed for the current level is lost	Level reset at the next quarterly window; pay protected	Team manager and Academy chair
Badge unused for 6 months	Refresher module and 10 supervised cases before routing resumes	Academy chair

Team coverage rule: every team keeps at least 2 holders of every core and advanced badge. The Academy owner publishes a team badge grid monthly; a gap of more than 30 days goes on the manager's scorecard and sets that team's training priorities.

Transition period, January–March 2027

Current staff start at the default level for their role: Seniors at L3, and Negotiators, Coders and Billers at L2. Each role is ranked on 2026 KPIs, and levels take effect on April 1, 2027. The full rules are in the Badges, Levels and Transition appendix.

Group (per role)	What happens	Result
Top 10%	Earn their role badges automatically, with no tests	Default level confirmed
Middle 80%	Optional skill assessment in January; 3 months to pass their role badge tests (February or March window)	Pass: confirmed. Fail: one level down. Pass the next level's test: one level up
Bottom 10%	Enrolled in the Academy and placed at L1	Can sit the skill assessment in any window to return to L2

Role badges: Negotiator C2, A2, C5. Coder A1 (if certified), C5. Biller C1, C3, C4, C5, plus A3 for MVA settlements. No one's pay goes down, and anyone moving up a level gets a guaranteed raise.

Salary bands by level

Base pay follows level, not individual badges: badges move a person up a level, and the level sets the band. Paying per badge would reward collecting badges the team doesn't need.

Bands are in **USD per month**, built from current pay: new recruits at \$1,000–1,100 and experienced staff at \$1,300–1,800. Team leads stay at **\$1,400–2,000** and managers at **\$2,000–3,000**.

Level	Band min (USD/month)	Midpoint	Band max	Midpoint gap to level below	Where current staff sit
L1 RCM Specialist I	1,000	1,150	1,300	—	New recruits (\$1,000–1,100) enter in the lower half
L2 RCM Specialist II	1,200	1,375	1,550	+20%	Lower part of today's experienced range

Level	Band min (USD/month)	Midpoint	Band max	Midpoint gap to level below	Where current staff sit
L3 Senior Specialist I	1,400	1,600	1,800	+16%	Upper part of today's experienced range
L4 Senior Specialist II	1,600	1,800	2,000	+13%	New level
L5 Team Lead	1,400	1,700	2,000	—	Matches today's team lead range
L5 Manager	2,000	2,500	3,000	+47% over Team Lead	Set as requested
L5 Senior Manager	To be set	—	—	—	New role

- Overlapping bands let a strong L2 earn more than a new L3, so experience inside a level is still rewarded.
- L4 and Team Lead share the \$2,000 ceiling, so a strong specialist can reach team lead pay without managing people.
- No raise is needed to fit team leads into their band, because it matches today's range.
- No one's pay goes down in the transition, including anyone moved down a level; see the Badges, Levels and Transition appendix.

Badge allowances and variable pay

Core badges carry no allowance because they are rewarded through promotion to L2. Advanced badges carry a monthly allowance, paid only while the badge is active and the team uses it, capped at 2 allowances per person.

Advanced badge	Monthly allowance (USD)	One-time award on earning (USD)	Company-paid extras
A1 Coding (Certified)	70	100	Certification exam, renewal and CEUs
A2 IDR Packet and Offer Strategy	70	100	External NSA/IDR training
A4 Payer Strategy	60	100	—

Advanced badge	Monthly allowance (USD)	One-time award on earning (USD)	Company-paid extras
A3 MVA and Adjuster Negotiation	45	75	—

A suspended badge stops its allowance from the next pay cycle; it resumes when the badge is re-earned.

Quarterly bonus: a target percentage of base pay, paid on these weights. Any missed deadline caused by the person's own error caps their bonus at 50% for that quarter.

Level	Target bonus (% of quarterly base)	Own portfolio results	Team results	QA and deadlines	Mentoring and specialty-group work
L1	5%	40%	20%	40%	—
L2	8%	50%	20%	30%	—
L3	10%	50%	20%	20%	10%
L4	12%	40%	20%	20%	20%
Team Lead	12%	20%	60%	20%	—
Manager	15%	—	70% (team) + 30% (all teams)	—	—

"Own portfolio results" means Net Recovery measured against others in the same tier, plus work units against target.

Compliance guard: coding work is never paid on dollars collected. For A1 holders, the coding part of the bonus uses accuracy and productivity only, so no one gains from coding a higher level than the chart supports.

Promotions

Promotions happen in quarterly windows, are open to anyone who meets the criteria, and are never limited to a vacancy for specialist levels.

1. **Eligibility check:** at the end of each quarter, ClickUp and the Academy chair list everyone who meets the badge and performance requirements for the next level. Badges are earned in the quarterly test windows.

2. **Calibration panel:** the Academy chair and 2 team managers from outside the person's team confirm each case.
3. **Effective date:** the first day of the next month. The new portfolio tier starts the same day.
4. **Feedback:** anyone eligible but not promoted gets the reasons in writing and a target quarter.

Move	Minimum time in current level	Pay increase
L1 → L2	6 months (none during the transition)	10% or the new band minimum, whichever is higher
L2 → L3	12 months (none during the transition)	12% or the new band minimum, whichever is higher
L3 → L4	18 months	12% or the new band minimum, whichever is higher
L3 or L4 → Team Lead (L5)	Passed coaching assessment; posted internally	8% or the band minimum, whichever is higher
Team Lead or L4 → Manager (L5)	12 months as team lead, or L4 plus leadership training; posted internally	15% or the band minimum, whichever is higher

Leadership seats (about 7 manager and 14 TL seats over the expansion) are filled by internal posting first. Only L3 and above can apply for TL.

Pay protection:

- No one's base pay goes down in the transition or when a level is reset.
- Anyone above their band maximum keeps their pay. Their base is frozen, and merit increases are paid as a one-time lump sum until the band catches up or they are promoted.
- Anyone below their band minimum after placement is raised to the minimum within 2 quarters.
- Every move up a level comes with a guaranteed raise.

Tenure rewards

Tenure is rewarded through merit growth inside the band and through benefits, not by moving people up a level. Level stays tied to skill, so long service never outranks proven competency.

Annual merit increase: set by performance rating and position in band, so people low in their band catch up faster. The figures below assume a 5% merit budget; scale them to the actual budget.

Rating	Below midpoint	Near midpoint	Above midpoint
Exceeds	8%	6%	4%
Meets	5%	4%	3%
Below	0%	0%	0%

Benefits by years of service:

Years of service	Added benefit
1	Company pays one certification or external course per year
2	+1 annual leave day
3	+2 annual leave days (total); retention bonus of 5% of annual base; first pick of shift or flexible-hours slots
5	+3 annual leave days (total); retention bonus of 8% of annual base; service award
10	+5 annual leave days (total); retention bonus of 10% of annual base; service award

Transition retention bonus: for staff whose skills are critical through the Jan 1 gateway cutover and the team launch (mainly experienced negotiators and the strongest coders and billers). Pay 10% of annual base, half in July 2027 and half in January 2028, conditional on still being employed and keeping a QA of 95% or higher.

Bridge night rota

Any L2, L3 or L4 member holding C2 can opt in to the bridge night rota. It is no longer limited to 2 team leads.

- **Hours:** 16:00–24:00 Beirut, Monday to Friday (08:00–16:00 US Central).
- **Staffing:** 2 members a night, at least one holding A2 as night lead. The rota reports to the Onshore–Offshore Liaison owner.
- **Duties:** check the tickets due that day, answer the US desk within 15 minutes, fix rejected tickets the same US day, and post the handover log.
- **Rota size:** 10 members at 1 night a week, or 20 members at 1 night every other week, or any size in between, set each quarter from the opt-ins.

Members on the rota	Bonus per member per quarter
10	\$3,000
15	\$2,000
20	\$1,500
30	\$1,000
50	\$600
100	\$300

The bonus comes from a fixed \$30,000 quarterly pool shared equally, within \$300–3,000 per member. It is paid in full when the rota meets its targets (98% first-pass tickets, answers within 15 minutes, no deadline missed because of a ticket) and the member works all assigned nights. Missed nights reduce the share pro rata. Transport home is covered.

Glossary

Codes and abbreviations used in this document.

Code	Stands for
C1–C5	Core badges: the five skills every specialist holds by L2 (C = core)

Code	Stands for
A1-A4	Advanced badges: expert skills; 2 are needed for L3 and 3 for L4 (A = advanced)
L1-L4	Specialist levels: RCM Specialist I and II, Senior Specialist I and II; L5 Principal is the leadership level
TL	Team Lead
OON	Out of network
NSA	No Surprises Act, the federal law that covers out-of-network emergency claims
NNSA	Non-NSA claims: claims that don't go through the No Surprises Act process
IDR	Independent Dispute Resolution, the federal process for NSA payment disputes
IDRE	IDR entity: the certified arbitrator that decides a dispute
OMB form / Open Negotiation	The 30-business-day negotiation required before IDR; its notice uses the OMB-approved form
QPA	Qualifying payment amount: the payer's median in-network rate
MVA	Motor vehicle accident claims
PIP / MedPay	Medical coverage inside an auto insurance policy
DOS	Date of service
ERA	Electronic remittance advice: the payer's electronic payment explanation
CPC / COC / CCS	Medical coding certifications
CEU	Continuing education unit, needed to keep a certification
QA	Quality assurance; also the QA department
PHI	Protected health information

Code	Stands for
Net Recovery	$\frac{\text{Collected} - \text{initial payment} - \text{IDR fees not refunded}}{\text{billed} - \text{initial payment}}$